

MAZE OF ALGORITHM

Cleaning up the digital space

The NCPCR has summoned Meta officials over child sexual abuse content in Instagram

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Tata Sons should go public immediately: RBI

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Trinamool groups meet EC over name, symbol

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India meets Sri Lanka in Asia Cup final

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BRICS bridges Iran-UAE divide, adopts New Delhi Declaration

Last-minute compromise on language about war in West Asia enables a consensus in the bloc, declaration calls for ‘maximum restraint’ in war with no specific mention of strikes; it rebukes Israel and calls for humanitarian aid to Gaza

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India forged a consensus of BRICS countries on Saturday, after Iran and the United Arab Emirates agreed to a last-minute compromise on the language used about the war in West Asia, allowing the 11-member grouping to adopt the New Delhi Declaration at a meeting chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The statement, which did not directly mention the attacks against Iran by the United States and Israel nor Iran’s subsequent strikes on its Persian Gulf neighbours, including the UAE, called for “maximum restraint” in the war. It made no separate mention of the Russian war in Ukraine.

The meeting was attended by the leaders of eight member countries, including Russian President Vladimir Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, and the leaders of Indonesia, Ethiopia, Egypt, and South Africa. Brazil and the UAE sent high-level representatives.

Significantly, given India’s close ties with Israel and Mr. Modi’s own visit to Jerusalem in February, the grouping declared its strong criticism of the country for its bombardment of Gaza. It expressed support for South Africa’s case against Israel in international courts, calling for the provision of humani-

Common ground

The New Delhi Declaration adopted at the 18th BRICS summit reaffirmed members’ commitment to the bloc’s spirit of mutual respect, sovereign equality, and democracy

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- Iran, UAE **back down** from tough positions as text on West Asia **omits direct references** to U.S.-Israel attack on Iran and Iran attack on UAE
- Support for Palestinian state and strong **8-para criticism** of Israel for strikes on Gaza and Lebanon, and displacement of Palestinians
- It condemns imposition of **unilateral coercive measures** like tariffs and sanctions
- Call for comprehensive reform of UN, support for **greater role** for Brazil, India in UNSC
- Support for BRICS trade mechanisms, including **intra-BRICS payments** through national currencies



- It strongly **condemns terrorism** in all forms, including the 2025 Pahalgam attack

tarian aid in Gaza.

The New Delhi declaration called for “comprehensive reform” of the United Nations, including support for Brazil and India to get a bigger role in the Security Council. It also stressed the need to protect civilians and expressed “deep concern” over attacks on civilian infrastructure and nuclear facilities in West Asia, in reference to the U.S. and Israel’s missile strikes in Iran.

Addressing the leaders, Mr. Modi said that 20 years after the grouping of emerging economies was originally formed, BRICS was “coming of age” with a “distinct identity” not aimed against others on the global stage. “We respect each other’s perspectives and move forward through consensus. We strive to move ahead with an approach that is not against anyone but instead seeks to take everyone along,” the Prime Minister

said, in a possible reference to the criticism of BRICS in the U.S. as an “anti-western” grouping.

Mr. Modi suggested that BRICS build a “troika” system like the G-20, so incoming and outgoing Presidents of the grouping bring continuity to discussions. He also proposed a road map for global governance reform, a seafarer distress network, and a BRICS global south mechanism for skill development in new technologies. Chinese President Xi Jinping, who held an hour-long bilateral meeting with Mr. Modi after the session, announced that China would take over the presidency of BRICS for the next year. The grouping had become the “world’s most influential platform for cooperation among emerging markets and developing countries,” he said.

The declaration also criticised the U.S. blockade of Cuba, and expressed

concern over violence in Sudan.

Previous ministerial meetings of BRICS this year had failed to issue joint statements on the Iran-UAE tussle. Sources privy to the negotiations said that Iran had wanted a strong condemnation of the U.S. and Israel for starting the war with strikes that assassinated its Supreme Leader, similar to the statement issued by the SCO grouping, which does not include the UAE. The UAE wanted “equal condemnation” of Iran’s attacks against its neighbours. Eventually, the text agreed to include non-specific references to the conflict.

‘Months of discussions’

The consensus was achieved through months of “threadbare” discussions, according to Sudhakar Dalela, Indian Sherpa at the talks and Secretary (Economic Relations) in the Ministry of External Af-

Modi makes a strong pitch for global reform

NEW DELHI

Highlighting the current imbalance between decision-makers and those impacted by their decisions, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday made a strong pitch for global reform and called for BRICS to transition from “rule-takers to rule-shapers.”» **PAGE 5**

fairs. He was addressing a media briefing after the closed BRICS session on the future of global governance and strengthening multilateralism. Side-stepping a question from *The Hindu* on whether India had asked for support from other leaders in BRICS to help convince Iran and UAE to agree to the draft language, he said that the cooperation and collaboration of all members was “key”.

He also underlined BRICS countries’ consensus against cross-border terrorism, with a specific reference to the Pahalgam terror attack in 2025.

On Sunday, Mr. Modi will chair a session of BRICS Plus countries and regional representatives for an outreach session that will include the leaders of Malaysia, Uzbekistan, Uganda, Vietnam, and Kazakhstan.

DETAILED COVERAGE ON
» **PAGES 4 & 5**

Xi, Modi welcome ‘steady progress’ in India-China ties

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday met Chinese President Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit in New Delhi, where the two leaders welcomed the “steady progress” in India-China relations since their last meeting in August 2025.

“We reviewed the full range of India-China relations. Also conveyed best wishes for China’s BRICS presidency that commences next year,” said Mr. Modi in a message after the meeting.

“The two leaders welcomed the steady progress in India-China bilateral relations since their last meeting in Tianjin in August 2025. They reaffirmed that both countries should take a strategic and long-term perspective of their ties. Differences should not become disputes,” the External Affairs Ministry said in a statement after the talks. Mr. Modi stressed the importance of “peace and tranquillity” in the border areas, describing the matter as an “essential basis for development of bilateral relations”.

Chinese State media reported that Mr. Xi said the two states have “different national circumstances”, but “China and India can learn from each other’s strengths and achieve shared development”.

Mr. Xi outlined four points on how to ensure the long-term, steady development of India-China relations and emphasised “rational strategic understanding”, “cooperation through mutual benefit”, “mutual respect and un-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi greets Chinese President Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI

derstanding”, and “openness and inclusiveness through multilateral cooperation” in the UN, SCO, BRICS, and G-20.

The External Affairs Ministry said the two leaders expressed their commitment to “a fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable resolution of the boundary question”, proceeding from the political perspective of their overall bilateral relations and the long-term interests of the two peoples.

“They (India and China) should pursue progress on bilateral relations and the boundary question in parallel, ensuring that each supports the other, and maintain peace and tranquillity in border areas,” a statement from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of China said.

Mr. Xi arrived with a large delegation earlier in the day for a two-day visit and was driven to the summit venue at Bharat Mandapam amid tight security.

‘Political settlement’

Speaking at the summit on the situation in West Asia,

Mr. Xi said the war has inflicted “serious losses” on the people of all countries in the region, and it is against the common interests of the international community. Chinese Foreign Ministry Spokesperson Mao Ning, referring to Mr. Xi’s speech, called for a “political settlement” of the crisis. “China will work with fellow BRICS members to play a due role in bringing peace and tranquillity to the Middle East,” said Mr. Xi, referring to India and China as “key members of the Global South”.

“We must keep the future of humanity and the well-being of our people at heart, join hands to drive high-quality cooperation within the expanded BRICS framework, advocate for an orderly multipolar world and an economic globalisation that is universally beneficial and inclusive, and inject greater positive energy into promoting global peace, stability, development, and prosperity,” he said. (With inputs from Ananth Krishnan in Beijing)

INSIDE



T.N. CM flags off Silverstone motor race in the U.K.

LONDON

Tamil Nadu CM C. Joseph Vijay flagged off the Michelin Le Mans Cup at the Silverstone circuit in Northampton, U.K., on Saturday evening. He also spent time with actor and motorsports racer Ajith Kumar, posing with him at the venue and in the race car. » **PAGE 2**

Anthropic calls for slowdown of AI development

NEW YORK

Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei called on AI companies to slow the rate at which they advance model capabilities amid safety concerns, outlining a three-step framework intended to pace development and create more time to manage its risks. » **PAGE 12**

NIA court issues arrest warrant against LeT chief

Peerzada Ashiq
JAMMU

A special National Investigation Agency (NIA) court in Jammu has issued a non-bailable arrest warrant against Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) founder Hafiz Muhammad Saeed in a case related to “providing weapons, money and directions to terrorists operating in the Kashmir Valley”.

“Keeping in view that the investigating agency has not been able to procure his attendance ordinarily, this motion is allowed. As such, a general warrant of arrest [non-bailable] is issued against the accused...,” the court said in its order.

The order came after the NIA moved an application for issuing a non-bailable warrant under Section 75 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) against him.

According to the Central agency, the “amir/chief/founder of the proscribed terrorist organisation LeT was operating from Pakis-



Wanted terrorist: LeT founder Hafiz Saeed is at present in Pakistan and is deliberately evading arrest to escape the law, says NIA. AP

tan and providing weapons, money, and directions to terrorists operating in the Kashmir Valley”. “The information is that the said terrorist is at present in Pakistan and is deliberately evading arrest to escape from the clutches of the law. Therefore, the NIA prays for the issuance of a non-bailable warrant of arrest against him,” the NIA said.

The agency referred to a case registered this year in which a person was arrested during checking at Gujar Tent Pandach in Ganderal by the J&K Police.

“During a personal

search of the rider, one Chinese grenade and 15 live rounds and cartridges were recovered from him. On preliminary questioning, the said person disclosed his name as Mohammad Naezeb Bhat, a resident of Fazal Haq Colony, Batpora, Srinagar. He failed to produce any valid justification for possessing the arms and ammunition,” the NIA said. “During the the investigation conducted so far, it came to light that the arrested Pakistani terrorist has been found to be associated with LeT/The Resistance Front,” the NIA said.

Saudi Arabia shuts down oil pipeline as Houthis tighten grip on Red Sea

Reuters
ADEN/DUBAI

Saudi Arabia has shut down its East-West pipeline after the vital oil conduit came under aerial attack in the widening West Asia war, threatening to send energy prices even higher.

The world’s largest crude oil exporter temporarily closed the pipeline after a drone attack that both Baghdad and Riyadh said had originated in Iraq, where Iranian-backed militias operate. Iraq dismissed a military commander on Saturday in response to the attack.

The 1,200-km pipeline running across the Arabian Peninsula had helped Saudi Arabia bypass a shipping logjam in the Strait of Hormuz, where tanker traffic has slowed to a trickle due to the six-month war between the U.S. and Iran.

The Saudi Energy Ministry said it had shut the pipeline as a precaution. The line had been moving 4.5 million barrels a day in re-



An infrastructure site after it was damaged by fire southeast of Medina along the route of Saudi Arabia’s East-West pipeline. AFP

cent months, amounting to 4.5% of global supply.

There was no immediate claim of responsibility for the strikes. Satellite images showed black smoke rising from an area of the pipeline south of Medina. The attack resulted in some injuries and damage that was being assessed, the Saudi Foreign Ministry said. U.S. President Donald Trump, visiting Ireland to attend a golf tournament at one of his resorts, said Iran was probably to blame for the attack. The war he launched six months ago

would probably end shortly after the U.S. midterm elections in November, when oil prices would “come tumbling down”, he added.

The Houthis seized the strategic island of Perim on Friday at the mouth of the Red Sea, in the Bab el-Mandeb strait.

Saudi Arabia’s de facto ruler, Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, phoned Mr. Trump last week and asked for U.S. military help fighting the Houthis, two sources told Reuters. He was told Wash-

ington would not intervene directly for now but would help with intelligence, the sources said.

Mr. Trump confirmed on Saturday he had spoken to the Crown Prince, and said the Houthis had also phoned his administration and asked for Washington not to become directly involved in the conflict.

The dual attacks reported on Friday – on the pipeline and Perim Island – could represent a dangerous escalation while diplomatic efforts to end the war have stalled. Saudi crude pumped through the pipeline to the Red Sea has been the main alternative source of West Asia oil while access to the Gulf has been cut off throughout the war.

Plan for counterattack

Meanwhile, Saudi-backed forces of the Yemeni government based in the south of the country indicated they would try to retake areas captured this week in the lightning offensive by the Houthis.

Nearly 250 videos found in devices seized from Prajwal's cell

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The forensic analysis of the mobile phone and pen drive seized from the prison cell, where former JD (S) MP Prajwal Revanna was lodged, revealed nearly 250 videos.

The investigators found 147 video clips on the phone and over 100 videos on the pen drive, seized during a recent Central Crime Branch search. The content reportedly included pornographic clips, OTT series, and movies.

Prajwal, the former MP from Hassan, is presently serving a life term for raping a domestic worker.

He has reportedly told investigators that he used the phone for contacting his mother and a friend.

Prajwal claimed that the phone was circulated among several prisoners in rotation and therefore he did not know who had downloaded the content.

Under scrutiny

The police are now scrutinising the mobile phone data, other digital evidence and call records. Investigators are expected to issue notices to those contacted from the device. Prajwal reportedly paid around ₹1 lakh to procure the phone, which was smuggled into the prison through a network including a jail staffer, the police said.

Prajwal is the grandson of former Prime Minister and JD(S) supremo H.D. Deve Gowda.

Charges by ED reflect shared agenda of Cong., BJP: Pinarayi

Opposition leader dares ED and Congress to 'specify the undue benefit' he extended to CMRL when he was Keralam CM; accuses ED of resurrecting false charges thrown out by Supreme Court

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Leader of the Opposition in the Keralam Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan on Saturday said there was something politically uncanny about the “BJP-led Union government’s” Enforcement Directorate (ED) seeking the cooperation of the Congress-ruled Keralam government to implicate him in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

At a press conference in Kannur, Mr. Vijayan wondered whether the move to implicate him in a corruption case was a “shared political agenda” of the Union and State govern-



In Keralam, Congress leaders seem to enthusiastically endorse the ED's attempts to target CPI(M) leaders

PINARAYI VIJAYAN
Leader of the Opposition

ments. Mr. Vijayan said non-BJP parties, including the Congress, had accused the ED of being a cat’s paw in the hands of the Union government to intimidate and arm-twist political opponents. “However, in Keralam, Congress leaders seem to enthusiastically endorse the ED’s attempts to target Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)]

leaders,” he said.

Mr. Vijayan said that the Vigilance Court, the Kerala High Court and the Supreme Court had thrown out the ED’s accusation that he had used the heft of his office as Chief Minister to help CMRL, make illicit profits in return for back-handers to Exalogic, for services allegedly not rendered. “Now, the ED, in an

act of desperation, is seeking the Congress government’s imprimatur to resurrect the false charges negated by the Supreme Court. The ED’s action amounts to judicial overreach, contempt of court, and double jeopardy.”

Mr. Vijayan dared the ED and the Congress to place on record what undue benefit he had accorded to CMRL as Chief Minister, allegedly in return for bribes routed through Exalogic. “The transaction between the two firms was through legitimate banking channels and tax-compliant. The SFIO’s allegation against Exalogic is under challenge in the Delhi High Court,” he reiterated.

Keralam still on the fence over PM SHRI scheme

The Hindu Bureau
PALAKKAD

The Keralam government has not decided whether to proceed with the controversial PM SHRI scheme, despite a fresh letter from the Centre seeking action on an agreement signed by the previous Left Democratic Front (LDF) government, General Education Minister N. Samsudheen said here on Saturday.

He said the United Democratic Front (UDF) was opposed to PM SHRI, but the government was examining its options over the

agreement signed by the previous government. The matter is being discussed at various levels and will come up before a Cabinet subcommittee next week, he said.

IUML and others

The Minister said the entire UDF opposed PM-SHRI, not just the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) and Muslim Youth League. While the government is bound to consider the agreement signed by its predecessor, it does not imply that PM SHRI will be implemented, he added.



N. Samsudheen

While, speaking to the presspersons, Muslim Youth League State president Munavvar Ali Shihab Thangal said the Muslim Youth League had dis-



Syed Munawwarali Shihab

cussed the issue with party leaders, and there is a consensus within the organisation that PM SHRI scheme should not be implemented in Keralam.

Complainant in ED case has Congress links: Jarkiholi

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Public Works Minister Sathish Jarkiholi, who was raided by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) recently, on Saturday said he knew who complained against him and had asked the Chief Minister to look into it.

Addressing the media, he said the “complainant had relations with the Congress, but was a BJP voter.” Asked whether the ED raids were a result of internal squabbling within the Congress or done at the behest of the BJP, he said: “So, it is like 50:50. It is difficult to tell anything”.

Mr. Jarkiholi said that the ED had only made allegations, which he would fight legally with facts.



Different roles: Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay with actor Ajith Kumar at the Silverstone circuit in Northampton, U.K., on Saturday.

T.N. Chief Minister flags off Silverstone motor race in the U.K.

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay flagged off the Michelin Le Mans Cup at the Silverstone circuit in Northampton, U.K., on Saturday evening, just past 5 p.m. local time. He also met with and spent time with his contemporary, actor and motorsports racer Ajith Kumar, posing with him at the venue and in the race car.

Mr. Vijay, who arrived in London on Friday, is on his first foreign visit after his party’s win in the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections in May 2026.

He is also expected to hold discussions with industry and company heads with a view to attracting investments for Tamil Nadu, during his visit. Earlier this month, Mr. Vijay had announced that he would establish a ‘Motor Sports City’ in Tamil Nadu to host Formula 1, 2, 3, and 4 races. He also announced the intention to build an ‘Olympic City’ in Chennai, which would train athletes

for the Olympics.

Tamil Nadu Public Works and Sports Minister Aadhav Arjuna could be seen with the Chief Minister prior to the start of the race.

Mr. Vijay sat briefly on the side of Mr. Ajith Kumar’s car prior the start of the race. A large crowd from the Tamil diaspora was in attendance in the stands.

Mr. Ajith Kumar, a participant in the Silverstone race and a former actor colleague of Mr. Vijay, thanked the latter for coming to the circuit. “My wish is to see these events come to India,” Mr. Ajith Kumar said in a reel that was posted on social media, adding that the U.K. tour programme would enable the Chief Minister to see what it would take for India and Chennai to host such events. Mr. Ajith Kumar, who is representing Ajith RedAnt by Virage (the team), is competing in the LMP3 Pro/Am category and driving a Ligier, along with French driver Romain Vozniak.

INBRIEF



Tiger kills buffalo in Kakinada, forest staff step up monitoring

A tiger attacked two buffaloes at Avelthi village in Kakinada district of Andhra Pradesh on Thursday night. One buffalo died in the attack. The male tiger, named Explorer, had crossed the Godavari about a week ago and entered Kakinada from Polavaram district. “Our teams are tracking the tiger and will alert people about its movements,” Kakinada District Forest Officer N. Ramachandra Rao said on Friday. The tiger has followed the same route twice since February. It was first tranquillised in Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema district in February and later released.

Assembly passes new Bill to build ‘modern Hyderabad’

The Telangana Legislative Assembly on Saturday passed the Core Urban Region (Integrated Governance) Bill, 2026. Introducing the Bill, Legislative Affairs Minister D. Sridhar Babu said Hyderabad was expanding very fast, and it would require uniform rules and decentralised administration for effective governance. The CURE Act will replace the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation Act, 1955. “Our government’s resolve is to build a modern Hyderabad that can compete with the world. That is the main objective of the Bill,” he said. (With PTI inputs)

A.P. Assembly building spire works to begin soon

Construction of the spire (pointed roof) of the Andhra Pradesh Assembly building coming up in Amaravati is set to begin in a week, construction agencies have informed Municipal Administration and Urban Development (MA&UD) Minister P. Narayana. The announcement came on Saturday during a review meeting organised by Mr. Narayana to assess the progress of construction works.

Power crisis triggers fresh blame game in Keralam

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The political blame game over the reasons for the current power crisis in Keralam intensified on Saturday, with the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government and the Opposition crossing swords over who is responsible for the disruptive electricity cuts bedevilling the State.

Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan argued that the LDF government’s “unthoughtful scrapping” of the “fiscally advantageous” long-term power purchase agreement signed by the Oommen Chandy-led UDF government with private power suppliers to ward off future shortages in 2011 had precipitated the situation.

Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan ac-



Power stir: A protest against power cuts outside the Electricity Board in Thiruvananthapuram recently. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

cused the UDF of obscuring facts to save face. He said the Kerala State Electricity Regulatory Commission (KSERC) had cancelled the agreement in 2023, citing a lack of regulatory approval.

Mr. Vijayan noted that the LDF had objected in 2011 to several controversial clauses in the agreement that “advantaged profit-driven private power

suppliers” over Kerala State Electricity Board (KSEB).

On Saturday, Mr. Satheesan said it was high time Keralam formulated a “modern power policy” with solar energy as a key component. He said that the government would introduce regulations next month to promote renewable energy in the power sector.

A.P. MedTech Zone to drive BRICS BioDesign initiative

The Hindu Bureau
VISAKHAPATNAM

The Andhra Pradesh Med-Tech Zone (AMTZ) is spearheading the new BRICS BioDesign Programme designed to advance cross-border healthcare innovation and medical technology across member nations.

The initiative was launched in New Delhi on Friday by the Principal Scientific Adviser to the Government of India, Ajay Kumar Sood.

Mr. Sood said the programme brings together global talent to solve critical healthcare challenges. He highlighted that combining scientific expertise and BioDesign accelerates the journey from ideas to implementation across the Global South.

The launch featured the exchange of a Memorandum of Agreement among



A view of Biovalley, an incubation centre set up at AMTZ in Visakhapatnam.

participating institutions and the unveiling of the official programme website.

AMTZ Managing Director Jitendra Sharma said the initiative builds crucial pathways from science to patients, enabling co-development, investment, and accessible medical technologies across emerging economies.

The initiative operates through a collaborative framework involving AMTZ,

the Office of the Principal Scientific Adviser, the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry, and the Science & Technology Cluster.

Industry involvement connects the BioDesign framework with commercial stakeholders and innovators to champion affordable and accessible medical technologies.

The initiative unites researchers, healthcare professionals, and academic institutions across BRICS nations to accelerate the transition from concept to deployable healthcare solutions.

Operating out of ‘The Atrium’ at AMTZ, the hub integrates clinical, design, engineering, prototyping, and translational capabilities to serve emerging economies across the Global South, said a release on Saturday.

Karnataka SIR leaves vulnerable families in a bind

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

Mohammed Sadiq, an auto driver, has seven members in his family, and all of them have received notices in the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in Karnataka. While four know when their hearings are scheduled, the other three notices have not yet reached the Booth Level Officers (BLOs).

With him being the only earner, and four members of his family having no documents except Aadhaar and ration cards, he wonders what will change after the hearing. While only

half of the family can establish their eligibility as Indian citizens, he said they are worried about what will happen if they do not appear for the hearing as they have no documents.

For lakhs in the city like Sadiq, it is a struggle to even understand what they are expected to prove at the hearing centres, and what to do if they have no documents.

Many citizens are saying that while BLOs and Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs) have been trying to help, the design of the system is such that they are also left with no option.



Polling personnel verify details of voters during a special campaign at Shivamogga in Karnataka. FILE PHOTO

For instance, notices are issued under two categories – no mapping and logical discrepancy. In logical discrepancy cases, while a discrepancy related to the

“self” only requires one document, discrepancies related to “progeny” require three documents – one of the elector (self), the other of the parent,

and a third of the grandparent.

AEROs point out that many are struggling to produce even a document for themselves, while in several cases, the electors who received notices have lost their parents, or are over 80 years old, with practically no records to prove.

In such cases, AEROs were seen assisting voters, by even uploading documents that are not part of the indicative list, such as ration cards.

“The system is accepting the documents, but we don’t know what will happen in the final rolls,” an AERO said.



BRICS INDIA 2026

Iran President, Abu Dhabi Crown Prince discuss regional hostilities

Both leaders underscore importance of ‘de-escalation’ as they meet on the sidelines of the 18th BRICS Summit; New Delhi Declaration calls for Israel to withdraw troops from Lebanon, halt policies aimed at forced displacement of Palestinians

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Against the backdrop of continued hostilities in West Asia, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and the Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi, Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, held talks in New Delhi on Saturday on the sidelines of the 18th BRICS Summit. The two sides discussed the regional hostilities and expressed support for “de-escalation”.

The conversation came ten days after Iran targeted military installations in the United Arab Emirates. The ‘New Delhi Declaration’, adopted at the BRICS Summit and announced by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has expressed “deep concern” about the multiple conflicts in West Asia, but stopped short of naming any of the major stakeholders, including the United States, in the text.

The Abu Dhabi Media Office said in a statement, “During the meeting, His Highness and the Iranian President discussed a number of regional and interna-



Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian with Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan in New Delhi. ANI

tional issues of mutual interest. They also underscored the importance of supporting efforts to ease tensions, promote de-escalation and strengthen regional stability, while advancing opportunities for peace and development for the peoples of the region.” Iranian state-owned news outlet IRNA said the meeting was held following “Iran’s consistent calls for and emphasis on strengthening relations with its southern neighbours”.

Mr. Pezeshkian said on Saturday that West Asia does not need the United States, which is at war with

Iran, to be a “regional policeman”. After a meeting with Malaysian Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim, the Iranian President said, “The territorial integrity and security of the region [West Asia] can only be guaranteed by its main players and the countries that comprise it.”

The conflicts in West Asia acquired prominence on the first day of the BRICS Summit on Saturday, with the joint declaration announced at the end of the first day’s leaders’ dialogue dropping any references to the contesting parties in order to reach a consensus.

“We express deep concern over the continued escalation of tensions in Middle East/West Asia and, recalling our respective national position, call for exercising maximum restraint, as well as avoiding actions that could further aggravate the situation,” said the New Delhi Declaration, highlighting the need to maintain “smooth flow of global trade, supply chains and energy, in accordance with applicable international law”.

The declaration further expressed “deep concern” regarding the continued fighting in the Gaza Strip, and called for “halting any policies aimed at forced displacement of Palestinians”. It also highlighted the need for a “just and lasting solution” to the Israel-Palestine conflict.

Palestinian statehood

The document extended support to the “establishment of a sovereign, independent and viable State of Palestine” within the “internationally recognised 1967 borders that includes the Gaza Strip, West Bank, with East Jerusalem as its

capital”. The declaration said that Israel has the “legal obligation” to ensure the supply of “humanitarian aid in Gaza” and called on Israel to respect the terms agreed with the Lebanese government and to withdraw its occupying forces from all Lebanese territories.

The declaration took a strong position on the attacks on the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon that have been continuing since the Israel-Palestinian conflict flared up in October 2023.

The conversation around West Asia in New Delhi gained further prominence with the arrival of Saudi Foreign Minister Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud on Saturday evening.

The External Affairs Ministry had earlier condemned attacks by the Houthis militia on Saudi sovereign territory and civilian and economic facilities, saying that “such attacks that undermined regional security and stability and threatened freedom of navigation in the Bab-el-Mandeb were unacceptable”.

BRICS declaration expresses concern over drug trafficking

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

BRICS countries on Saturday expressed concern over illicit drug production, trafficking and abuse worldwide and welcomed the Guwahati Declaration issued by the chiefs of anti-narcotics agencies of the grouping countries in July which had underscored the need for timely intelligence sharing on the operations of narco-gangs.

“We express concern over the situation with illicit drug production, trafficking and abuse worldwide, and recognise that it seriously threatens public security, health, safety and well-being of humankind and undermines the need to enhance the timely exchange of information, and intelligence on narco-gangs. PTI

During the meeting in July, India had pressed for drug law enforcement agencies of the BRICS countries to build a partnership founded on speed, mutual trust and seamless real-time intelligence sharing that transcends borders and enables decisive action against transnational drug syndicates.

The 45-page New Delhi Declaration welcomed



Guwahati Declaration stressed the need to enhance the timely exchange of information, and intelligence on narco-gangs. PTI

“the Guwahati Declaration issued by the BRICS Heads of Anti-Drug Agencies that would facilitate operational and technical cooperation among BRICS Anti-Drug Agencies”.

The Guwahati Declaration adopted in July had underscored the need to enhance the timely exchange of information, intelligence and best practices, consistent with national laws and international obligations.

The Declaration had also emphasised the promotion of innovative technologies, digital tools and data-driven approaches to strengthen law enforcement and regulatory efforts against illicit drug trafficking.

Murmu meets Pezeshkian, lays stress on diplomacy

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

President Droupadi Murmu on Saturday met her Iranian counterpart Masoud Pezeshkian during which she reiterated India’s commitment to the pursuit of enduring peace in the region and called for conflicts to be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy.

Welcoming Mr. Pezeshkian on his first visit to India, Ms. Murmu expressed appreciation for the support extended by Iran during India’s BRICS presidency.

Long-standing bond

The two leaders discussed the long-standing bonds of friendship between Iran and India, including their strong cultural and people-to-people ties, a statement issued by the Rashtrapati Bhavan said.

Ms. Murmu reiterated India’s commitment to the pursuit of enduring peace in the region and called for conflicts to be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy, it said.

Mr. Pezeshkian, who is in New Delhi to participate in the BRICS Summit, called on President Murmu at the Rashtrapati Bhavan.

BRICS nations fortify disease monitoring

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

BRICS leaders on Saturday called for stronger cooperation in disease surveillance and medical product regulation, welcoming the establishment of a dedicated sub-working group to advance an integrated early warning system for the prevention and response to mass infectious diseases.

In their New Delhi Declaration, the leaders stressed the importance of strengthening health infrastructure and local production of medical products to enhance preparedness for future health emergencies and ensure timely, affordable and equitable access to healthcare services, vaccines, therapeutics and diagnostics. They also called for strengthened collaboration among

BRICS medical products regulatory authorities and welcomed efforts to develop a common GxP white paper consolidating regulatory best practices and technical approaches.

The leaders recognised that infectious disease outbreaks, zoonotic threats, antimicrobial resistance and other public health emergencies transcend national borders and require stronger international cooperation.

Recognising the central role of the World Health Organization and the amended International Health Regulations (2005), the leaders underscored the importance of resilient surveillance, early warning and rapid response systems and coordination.

The initiative is aimed at boosting collective preparedness against infectious disease threats through closer coordination.

PM holds series of bilateral meetings; hails India-UAE ties

Kallol Bhattacharjee
T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Saturday, after a meeting with Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan of the United Arab Emirates, that strong ties between India and the UAE are a sign of stability during “a time of uncertainty” in West Asia.

Mr. Modi also held bilateral meetings with the Prime Ministers of Ethiopia, Vietnam and Malaysia on the sidelines of the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi.

The visit of Sheikh Khaled, the Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi and the chairman of the Abu Dhabi Executive Council, has been seen as a tactical move by the UAE amid the conflict in West Asia, in which the Gulf country and fellow BRICS member Iran have found themselves on opposing sides.

“India-UAE ties have

been transformed over the last few years. Now, we are raising our ambitions even higher,” said Mr. Modi after the meeting, adding that the discussion covered matters such as the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor project. “At a time of uncertainty in West Asia, a strong India-UAE is a symbol of stability, prosperity and peace,” he said.

The External Affairs Ministry said in a statement that the two leaders discussed major investment opportunities in India. “The leaders acknowledged the important role that L’imad, the UAE’s newest sovereign investment fund, could play in further deepening the India-UAE partnership for mutual benefit,” the Ministry said. According to the Ministry, the discussion also covered cooperation in areas like defence, space, nuclear energy, technology and innovation.

The meeting also re-



Bolstering alliance: Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Malaysian Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim in New Delhi on Saturday. ANI

viewed the announcement by the UAE’s International Holding Company that it would invest \$11.5 billion in the integrated greenfield aluminium project in Odisha. The project is expected to position Odisha as a global aluminium manufacturing hub and provide employment opportunities to a large number of industrial workers.

On Saturday, Mr. Modi also held discussions with Ethiopian Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed Ali. According

to the Ministry, the talks were aimed at further strengthening the bilateral strategic partnership and the two leaders “reviewed progress across key sectors, including economic cooperation, defence and security partnership, and capacity building”.

“Prime Minister Modi expressed appreciation for Ethiopia’s participation in the 18th BRICS Summit and noted that its presence helped in reinforcing the collective voice of the Glo-

bal South,” the Ministry said.

Another bilateral meeting on the sidelines of the summit on Saturday was between Mr. Modi and Vietnamese Prime Minister Le Minh Hung.

“The meeting provided an opportunity for both leaders to review the progress made in bilateral ties, which were elevated to an Enhanced Comprehensive Strategic Partnership during the State Visit of H.E. Mr. To Lam, President of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam, to India in May 2026,” the Ministry statement said.

‘Time-tested friendship’

The statement affirmed the “time-tested friendship” that India and Vietnam share, which it added was rooted in shared civilisational heritage, mutual trust, and understanding. “Vietnam is a key pillar of India’s Act East Policy and an important partner in India’s broader engagement

with Southeast Asia,” it said.

During their bilateral meeting on Saturday, Mr. Modi and Prime Minister of Malaysia, Anwar Ibrahim, reviewed the progress in bilateral cooperation across a range of areas, including trade and investment, defence and security, semiconductors, infrastructure, digital economy, energy, fintech, education, tourism, and people-to-people ties, the Ministry said.

“Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim conveyed Malaysia’s concurrence to the establishment of a Consulate General of India in Kota Kinabalu, Sabah,” it said in a statement.

“Prime Minister Modi appreciated Malaysia’s support in strengthening ASEAN-India relations,” the statement said, adding, “The leaders expressed their commitment to advancing the India-Malaysia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.”

‘Brazil, India forging ties for a changing world’

Shobhan Saxena
NEW DELHI

Brazil’s Foreign Minister Mauro Vieira on Saturday praised India’s BRICS presidency and added that bilateral trade between India and Brazil could exceed the \$30 billion target well before 2030. In an interview with *The Hindu*, he also emphasised that it is not correct to view BRICS as an “anti-West alliance”.

Responding to a question on commercial ties, Mr. Vieira said that following President Lula da Silva’s visit to India in February, Brazil and India are rapidly expanding bilateral trade past last year’s \$15 billion toward \$20 billion, driven by major Brazilian companies. “If some of the deals currently being developed by Embraer, Vale, WEG and other companies materialise, bilateral trade could exceed \$30 billion in the short term,” he said. Highlighting his long di-



Global vision: Brazilian Foreign Minister Mauro Vieira addresses the Leaders’ Session of the BRICS Business Forum in New Delhi. ANI

plomatic friendship with External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, Mr. Vieira pointed out that their frequent personal consultations greatly enhance dialogue, noting that “our positions are very similar – practically the same – on multilateralism and global governance”.

On India’s presidency

Reflecting on India’s BRICS presidency, Mr. Vieira said India has smoothly carried

forward key initiatives. Emphasising the growing importance of the New Development Bank as a vital alternative to the outdated 80-year-old Bretton Woods institutions, Mr. Vieira said: “With the BRICS bank, we can have a faster, more agile and more efficient system, under the control of the countries that own the bank and have a direct interest in its success.” Highlighting the high-

profile attendance of Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin at the summit in New Delhi, Mr. Vieira stated that their presence underscores India’s pivotal global role and the undeniable geopolitical weight of the group.

He added that the unique organisational structure of BRICS allows major regional powers with complex bilateral differences to engage directly, because “it [BRICS] provides a space where dialogue can take place with greater proximity and informality”, thereby facilitating critical diplomatic stabilisation.

On the issue of new members joining the group, Mr. Vieira said the group of emerging countries has now entered a necessary strategic phase focused on consolidation rather than further enlargement, prioritising the full integration of new

members, enhancing structured dialogue with partner countries, and managing rotating presidencies effectively without immediately creating a permanent administrative secretariat.

Responding to a question on the focus of Brazil’s foreign policy, Mr. Vieira said it relies on peace, constitutional multilateralism, and active diplomacy over military force. Brazil advocates non-intervention, peaceful conflict resolution, and international law, he said.

“President Lula champions this approach by expanding trade and political ties worldwide. Through a vast global diplomatic network, Brazil bridges divides, maintains open dialogue with competing nations, and positions itself as a committed mediator for global cooperation,” Mr. Vieira added. (For the interview, visit newsth.live/Brazil-India)

Dignitaries savour Indian delicacies at BRICS dinner

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

‘Paneer lababdar’, ‘gucchi marmik’, ‘millet pulao’, and ‘shahtoot phirni’ for desserts were among the Indian delicacies served to the leaders and delegates of the BRICS Summit at a gala dinner hosted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the Bharat Mandapam on Saturday.

India is hosting the BRICS Summit at the sprawling venue in central Delhi on September 12-13. The first day saw the presence of Chinese President Xi Jinping, Russian President Vladimir Putin and several other heads of state.

The menu included ‘khandvi mille’ and ‘khumb galouti’ as starters, people familiar with the matter said. ‘Khandvi



At the gala dinner hosted by PM Modi. @MPPCHAUDHARYX

mille’ is a feuille steamed gram-flour roll, tempered with mustard, coconut and curry leaves. It is served with kesar mango, micro-greens and yoghurt dressing. ‘Khumb galouti’ is tender pan-grilled mushroom kebabs with mint pearls, served on a bed of sheer-mal bread, they said.

The main course offered ‘paneer lababdar’ – cot-

tage cheese cubes simmered in a gravy of shallots and tomato; ‘gucchi marmik’ – Himalayan morel mushrooms and tender asparagus, simmered with saffron, raisins, and mamarra almonds; and ‘carrot bean poriyal’ – carrots and green beans toasted in South Indian spices in virgin coconut oil and finished with grated coconut.

BRICS INDIA 2026



Strengthening ties: (from left) Vladimir Putin, Narendra Modi, and Xi Jinping hold hands during the summit in New Delhi. REUTERS



A closer look: Global leaders with Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the 'Bharat Innovates Exposition' at Bharat Mandapam. PTI



Banquet bus: Union Ministers Kiren Rijiju, Arjun Ram Meghwal and others take a bus to a banquet hosted by the Prime Minister. PTI



High alert: Security personnel keeping guard during the BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

PM urges BRICS leaders to draw up 10 global governance reform proposals

Modi proposes mechanism to follow up on BRICS initiatives; calls for development of a reform road map focused on representation in UN Security Council and financial institutions, creation of a Seafarers' Emergency Support Network and transformation of the Global South into 'rule-shapers'

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday made a strong pitch for global reform, highlighting the current imbalance between decision-makers and those impacted by their decisions, and called for BRICS to transition from "rule-takers to rule-shapers".

Towards this, he proposed that the leaders of the BRICS nations gathered in New Delhi for the 18th BRICS Summit use the opportunity to arrive at 10 proposals for global governance reform, which can be developed into a BRICS Reform Road map.

While delivering his welcome address, the Prime Minister took note of the fact that the BRICS grouping was now 20-years-old and, as such, was entering a new phase of maturity and responsibility.

"Over the past 20 years, BRICS has strengthened its distinctive identity on the global stage," Mr. Modi said. "We respect each other's perspectives and move forward through consensus. We seek to move forward, not against anyone, but with an approach of taking everyone along."

"Now is the time for us



Green gesture: Russian President Vladimir Putin, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and Chinese President Xi Jinping at a tree plantation initiative during the BRICS Summit in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI

to translate our unity and consensus within BRICS into concrete outcomes on the global stage," he added.

Continuity in BRICS

The Prime Minister said that, over the next 20 years, BRICS must work on a new and ambitious agenda.

"This must begin with our own working systems," he said. "The BRICS presidency changes every year, but our institutional momentum should not stop because of this."

Towards this, Mr. Modi proposed a BRICS Conti-

nuity and Implementation Mechanism, which the BRICS Troika could use to follow up on all initiatives and outcomes.

"We can create a secure digital repository in which, alongside every decision, the nodal point, deadline and implementation status can be recorded," Mr. Modi said.

Reform beyond BRICS

Mr. Modi noted that the current structure of global governance resembles a pyramid, with power and decision-making concentrated at the top, while countries at the bottom are

affected by these decisions but are unable to shape them.

"The Global South is today on the front line of global crises, but in the back row when it comes to decision-making," he emphasised.

"We must transform this pyramid of privilege into a platform of partnership, where every country has a voice, and the development of humanity remains at the centre of every effort."

"With this objective, I propose that we jointly prepare 10 proposals for

global governance reform, which we can seek to develop into a BRICS Reform Road map by the next Summit," Mr. Modi added.

The Prime Minister said that, while preparing this road map, the assembled leaders should focus on three key aspects: representation, responsiveness and rule-making.

"First, on representation, I would like to say that the reform of the UN Security Council can no longer be delayed," Mr. Modi said. "Text-based negotiations on this issue must be linked to a definite timeline and clear outcomes."

He added that voting power, leadership positions, and policy priorities in financial institutions must reflect today's economic realities.

"Countries that are driving global economic growth should also have an appropriate role in shaping global economic governance," Mr. Modi emphasised.

Regarding responsiveness, he said that trust in global institutions will be established only when they are capable of providing effective solutions to problems.

"We must focus on the speed, scale and last-mile impact of our collective

response," Mr. Modi said, giving the example of how, despite making a significant contribution to global trade, seafarers often feel a lack of support during difficult times.

"My proposal is: can we create a Seafarers' Emergency Support Network," he asked the assembled leaders. "Through this network, the maritime authorities and missions of the concerned countries could be connected. This could provide support for distress alerts, medical assistance, informing families and evacuation."

Shaping global rules

The Prime Minister said that it is important to ensure equal participation in determining the global rules of the future.

"AI, cyberspace, outer space, biotechnology and critical technologies are not only creating future opportunities; they are also shaping the rules of the future," Mr. Modi said. "We must work to transform the Global South from rule-takers into rule-shapers."

"Friends, the message from the BRICS Summit being held in India should be clear: If our future is shared, then the right to shape that future must also be shared," he added.

INBRIEF



PM greets dignitaries against backdrop of iconic T.N. temple

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday welcomed BRICS leaders against a backdrop featuring Tamil Nadu's iconic Ramanathaswamy temple, one of the Char Dham shrines where Lord Rama is believed to have performed puja after his victory over the demon king Ravana. At Bharat Mandapam, where the 18th BRICS Summit is under way, the Prime Minister received the leaders of BRICS nations, including Russian President Vladimir Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping, and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian. The leaders shook hands and posed for pictures against the backdrop featuring the iconic temple. Welcoming Mr. Xi, Mr. Modi also explained to him the significance of the temple. The Ramanathaswamy temple is the only one dedicated to Lord Shiva among the Char (four) Dham shrines. PTI



Odisha's Koraput coffee given to global delegates at BRICS

Odisha's Koraput coffee was given to delegates and journalists at the BRICS Summit in New Delhi, putting the tribal farmers-grown Arabica brand in international spotlight, officials said on Saturday. Tiger Bright, a brand of Koraput coffee, was included in the kits distributed to media personnel and delegates at the summit by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA). Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi welcomed the recognition for the State's home-grown coffee and said it provided a platform to showcase Odisha's local produce. "Over the past few days, I have been speaking about #Odisha on global platforms, inviting the world to see the opportunities, strength and potential of our State. Today, it is especially heartening to see Koraput coffee telling another side of Odisha's story at the BRICS India 2026," Mr. Majhi said in a post on X. He said the initiative reflected the spirit of 'Vocal for Local' promoted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. PTI



How Delhi is managing air traffic during the summit

Behind the red carpets, motorcades and ceremonial welcomes for BRICS leaders is a tightly coordinated aviation operation involving around 35 special aircraft, multiple airports, controlled airspace and carefully timed movements to accommodate foreign dignitaries without disrupting Delhi's regular commercial flights. The operation spans the Indira Gandhi International Airport, the Indian Air Force's Palam technical area and other airports being used to park visiting aircraft. The CISF, Indian Air Force, aviation authorities and other security agencies are coordinating the movements. For regular passengers, the airport operation begins with processing inside the terminal before they board their aircraft via an aerobridge. VVIP movements are kept separate. The Directorate General of Civil Aviation has also imposed restrictions on non-scheduled flight operations.

New Delhi Declaration focuses on MSMEs, raises concerns over rise of unilateral tariff measures

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The New Delhi Declaration, adopted by the BRICS nations at their 18th summit in New Delhi on Saturday, devoted significant focus to the needs of micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) and ways to help them move up the global value chain. India is the chair of BRICS in 2026, with China taking over the chairship in 2027.

The latest declaration also carried forward most of the economic issues raised during the last summit in Rio de Janeiro, including concerns about the "rise of unilateral tariff and non-tariff measures", the "imposition of unilateral coercive measures", trade in local currencies, and the need for reforms in the World Trade Organization (WTO), International Monetary Fund (IMF), and World Bank.

The BRICS nations also advocated for the accession of Ethiopia and Iran to the WTO.

MSMEs in focus

The declaration acknowledged the initiatives by the SME Working Group and commended India's Chairship for convening the inaugural BRICS SME Forum



All ears: South African President Cyril Ramaphosa at the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi. AFP

in Agra and releasing a report titled "Advancing MSME Competitiveness in BRICS: Strengthening Access to Finance & Technology and Sustainable Growth".

It further recognised this report for its potential to foster cooperation, exchange best practices and promote inclusive growth among MSMEs across BRICS countries

"We reaffirm our commitment to strengthening the internationalisation of MSMEs as a driver of economic growth and prosperity," the declaration said. "We acknowledge that access to affordable finance remains a primary bottleneck and structural constraint, limiting MSMEs' participation in trade and integration into

Global Value Chains (GVCs)," it said.

"We understand the importance of promoting innovative financing mechanisms, including digital and platform-based multis-takeholder solutions for facilitating easier access to trade finance for MSMEs," it added.

It further welcomed the Jaipur Consensus to study the establishment of an Invoice Discounting Mechanism for BRICS members aimed at facilitating invoice discounting, which would help MSMEs unlock working capital and strengthen their participation in international trade.

The declaration also mentioned several initiatives of cooperation between the BRICS nations in areas of Special Economic

Zones, manufacturing, value addition, diamonds and precious metals, customs facilitation, logistics, railways, aviation, and industrial upgrade.

Trade concerns

"We voice serious concerns about the rise of unilateral tariff and non-tariff measures which distort trade and are inconsistent with WTO rules," the declaration said.

It noted that such measures threaten to further reduce global trade, disrupt global supply chains, and introduce uncertainty into international economic and trade activities, which could potentially exacerbate existing economic disparities and negatively affect prospects for global economic development.

The declaration added that BRICS would work together to enhance the WTO's responsiveness to trade disruptions and the needs and priorities of emerging markets and developing economies.

"We condemn the imposition of unilateral coercive measures that are contrary to international law, and reiterate that such measures, *inter alia* in the form of unilateral economic sanctions and secondary

sanctions, have far-reaching negative implications for the human rights, including the rights to development, health and food security, of the general population of targeted states, disproportionately affecting the poor and people in vulnerable situations, deepening the digital divide and exacerbating environmental challenges," the declaration said.

Global bodies' reform

The BRICS nations re-declared their "unwavering support" for reform of the WTO and for strengthening a "non-discriminatory, open, equitable, transparent, fair, inclusive, predictable and rules-based multilateral trading system", with the WTO at its core.

"Echoing the aspirations of the Global South to fully integrate into the multilateral trading system, we strongly support Ethiopia and Iran's bid for accession to the WTO," the declaration said. "We acknowledge China for expanding its zero-tariff treatment to cover 53 African countries with which it has diplomatic ties." The declaration also went on to call for reforms of the World Bank, the United Nations (UN), the UN Security Council, and the IMF.



Desolate view: A quaint window of a house that stands empty in Gattumeedapalle.



Not welcome: Doors remain locked as families have moved to Kosuvaripalle.



Gathering dust: A handpump that was once used for drinking water.



In disuse: Subbi Reddy, who owns land in Gattumeedapalle, inspects the village well that has dried up.

A village with no people

Gattumeedapalle was once a bustling hub of groundnut cultivation in Andhra Pradesh; however, repeated crop failure due to lack of water has forced families to move away to find alternative sources of livelihood



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In just 10 years, an entire village in Andhra Pradesh has emptied out. The houses still stand, bereft of their owners who have moved away after repeated failures of crops that were dependent on rain. Gattumeedapalle, about 125 km from Tirupati, is now a ghost village. Located in Kosuvaripalle panchayat of Annamayya district, the village sprawled across nearly 1,000 acres and had nearly 300 acres under groundnut cultivation. But the vagaries of the weather and depleting groundwater levels in the village gradually forced the people to move away. For some time, those left in the village depended on a single borewell for drinking water but in the end, those families too moved away. Thimmakkagari Subbi Reddy was once a farmer who cultivated groundnuts in the village. He has now moved down the hill and taken up work as a shepherd to make ends meet. He sadly says he has written off his village permanently and would not want to return. Like Subbi Reddy, several other villagers have moved seeking a

livelihood. The shift began in 2015 when some families moved to Kosuvaripalle or shifted to the nearby Madanapalle town. For a while, some families stayed on, determined to make the best of it. However, with no solution in sight, they too started moving away in search of new livelihood sources. “An exodus triggered panic among the few who were finally left. Then, everyone decided to move,” says Subi Reddy. Many of the houses were vacated but the furniture and electronic items were left behind. Theft grew rampant when news of the empty village spread. Even the temple bell was not spared. “I would once hear the temple bell while grazing cattle. I did not think that even that would get stolen,” he says. Most of the people who migrated from the village now support themselves by working for daily wages in nearby towns. Only a large telephone tower watches from atop the hillock in the village that once bustled with activity.

Text by A.D. Rangarajan



Uninhabited abode: The dilapidated huts present a sorry state of affairs.

News in Frames



Empty classroom: The Mandal Parishad Primary School, which has been closed down by the government for want of takers.



Fading memory: The presence of a smart meter at a house shows that the residents were till recently staying in the village.



Silent sentinel: The uninhabited Gattumeedapalle village is now home to a mobile phone tower.



Stepping away: Villagers who once stayed in Gattumeedapalle and have now settled in Kosuvaripalle.



Left behind: A dish antenna that has not been removed even after the family moved out of the village.



New destination: A view of Kosuvaripalle, where the families began moving to in 2015.

PROFILES

The new lords of the Red Sea

The Houthis vs Saudi Arabia

A parallel state in Yemen, an ideologically committed base, years of warfare, control of the Red Sea coastline and sustained Iranian support have all helped the Shia militant group transform itself into a formidable territorial army and naval force

Stanly Johnny

On July 13, an Iranian civilian aircraft carrying a high-level Houthi delegation was heading towards Sana'a, Yemen's capital. Under an unwritten understanding between the Houthis (or Ansar Allah), who control northern and northwestern Yemen, including Sana'a, and the country's Saudi-backed government, planes seeking to land in Houthi-held territory were required to obtain prior approval. The Houthi delegation had left Yemen on July 3 on another Iranian aircraft to attend the funeral of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Iran's Supreme Leader who was assassinated by the U.S. and Israel on February 28.

Yemen's Saudi-backed government had protested the Iranian plane transporting Houthi leaders. It also opposed the delegation taking an Iranian plane back home, and instead offered to facilitate their return on a non-Iranian airline. The government's main concern was that the flight could also be used to transport personnel of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and military equipment to Yemen. The Houthis, nevertheless, chose to return on a Mahan Air flight. To prevent the aircraft from landing, Saudi-backed forces bombed the runway of Sana'a airport, forcing the plane to land in Hodeidah. This was the trigger.

The Houthis responded by bombing Saudi energy infrastructure and launching an offensive in Hodeidah and Taiz governorates. They also imposed a naval blockade on Saudi vessels in the Red Sea. Within two months, the Houthis made dramatic territorial gains, seizing the entire Red Sea coastline of Yemen and taking the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, the narrow chokepoint connecting the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden, under their control.

A revivalist movement

The roots of the Houthi movement can be traced to 'Believing Youth', a Zaydi revivalist group founded in Northern Yemen in the early 1990s. Hussein al-Houthi and his father, Badr al-Din al-Houthi, influential Zaydi clerics in

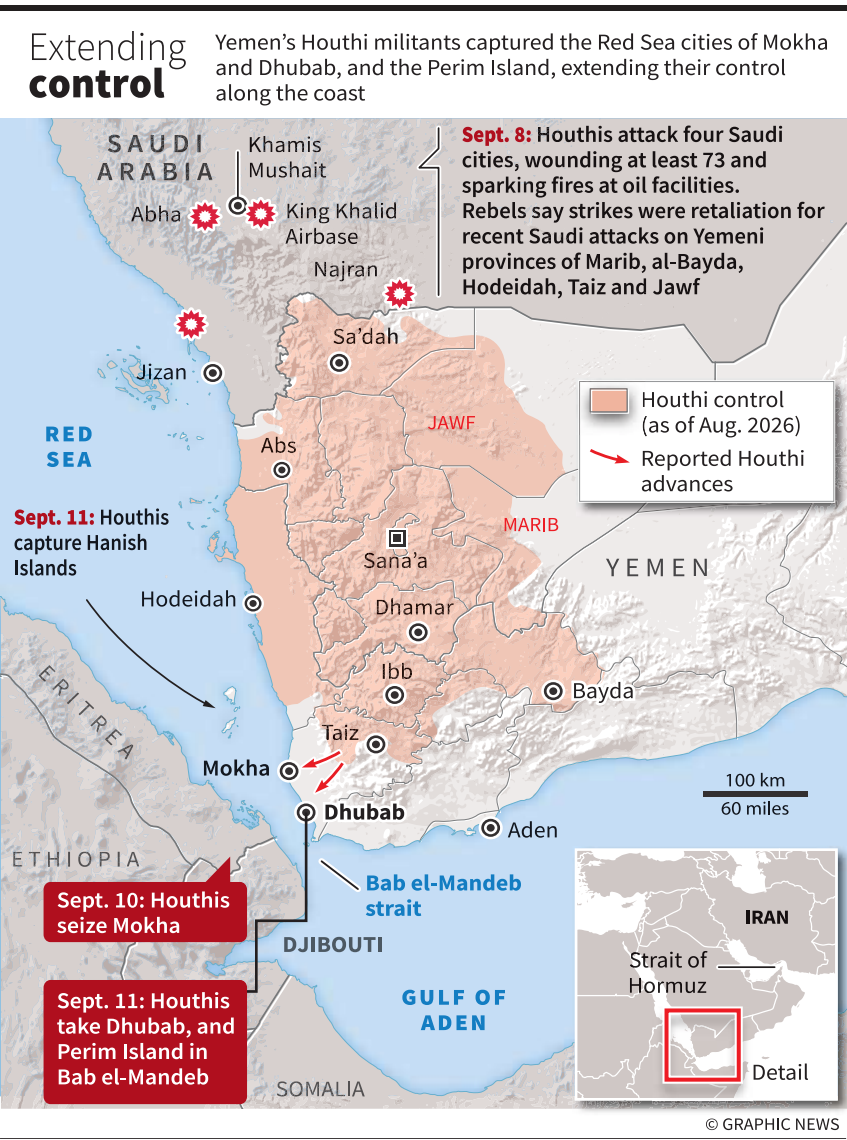
northern Yemen, became the movement's leading figures. Inspired by the Iranian revolution of 1979 and the rise of Hezbollah in southern Lebanon in the 1980s, Badr al-Din and his sons started building vast social and religious networks among the Zaydi Shias of Yemen, who make up roughly one-third of the Sunni-majority country's population.

In 2004, Ali Abdullah Saleh's government, upset with the growing popularity and rebellion of the Houthis, issued an arrest warrant against Hussein. He resisted the arrest, starting an insurgency. In September, government troops attacked the rebels and killed Hussein. But the movement he founded would only grow, forcing Saleh to step down in 2012 and capturing Sana'a in 2014.

Alarmed by the rise of an Iran-aligned Shia militia across its southern border, Saudi Arabia formed a coalition and declared war against the Houthis in 2015. An intense bombing campaign followed, but the Saudi-led coalition failed to dislodge the rebels, who built a parallel state in northern Yemen. In 2022, amid a broader rapprochement between Iran and Saudi Arabia, the Houthis and Saudi-backed forces agreed to a ceasefire.

The Saudis also struggled to build a credible counterweight to the Houthis inside Yemen. The top leadership of the government was based in Saudi Arabia, while in the south, the UAE-backed Southern Transitional Council broke with the government and pursued its own separatist agenda, further weakening the anti-Houthi camp.

The ceasefire allowed the Houthis to consolidate their position in the north and northwest, despite economic woes. The parallel state, an ideologically committed base, years of warfare and sustained Iranian support enabled the group to transform itself into a formidable territorial army. Their access to the Red Sea, a key shipping route, raised their profile as a naval force. When Israel launched a devastating war on Palestinians in Gaza following Hamas's October 7, 2023 attack, Houthis "declared war" against Israel "in solidarity with the



Palestinians". In March 2025, U.S. President Donald Trump announced a major air and naval operation against the Houthis, threatening to destroy the group. Despite the enormous firepower brought against them, the Houthis continued launching missiles and drones at U.S. naval forces. Seven weeks later, Mr. Trump announced an end to the U.S. strikes.

After the U.S. and Israel launched the war on Iran on February 28, the Houthis, to the surprise of many, stayed out of the conflict. Iran retaliated by attacking American bases in the Persian Gulf and shutting down the Strait of Hormuz. The

Houthis understood that Iran's closure of the strait strengthened their strategic position: they had the capacity to disrupt maritime traffic through the Red Sea. They also wanted the Saudi blockade of their air space and ports lifted. In the first week of July, as a second round of bombings between Iran and the U.S. was unfolding, the Houthis decided to test Saudi Arabia's resolve by sending a delegation to Iran on an Iranian plane. Saudi Arabia responded by bombing the runway at Sana'a airport as the delegation was returning, effectively breaking the ceasefire. Then the Houthis moved rapidly up

the escalation ladder.

Renewed conflict brings Saudi Arabia under enormous pressure. After traffic through the Strait of Hormuz was disrupted by Iran, Riyadh increasingly relied on its Red Sea terminals to export crude oil. Saudi Arabia's East-West Pipeline, connecting its oil fields in the east with the ports on the Red Sea, allowed the Kingdom to skirt the impact of the disruptions in Hormuz to a certain extent. But the Houthis, after the ceasefire broke down, directly targeted Saudi oil infrastructure, apparently in coordination with Iran-aligned Shia militants in Iraq. On September 11, the pipeline was shut, following drone attacks from Iraq. In Yemen, in a lightning offensive launched in early September, the Houthis captured the port cities of Mokha and Dhubab and the Perim Island in the Bab el-Mandeb, extending their control along the coast and into the strait.

Two chokepoints

More than 20% of the world's seaborne oil trade passed through the Strait of Hormuz before the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran. The Red Sea, which connects Asia and Europe through the Suez Canal in the north and Bab el-Mandeb in the south, typically carries roughly 12-15% of global trade. This means that Iran and Ansar Allah now have the ability to exert pressure on two of the world's critical maritime chokepoints.

On February 27, before the war, both the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab el-Mandeb Strait were open, and Iran was prepared to make concessions on its nuclear programme. On June 17, when the U.S. and Iran signed an MoU, committing Tehran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz in return for sanctions relief from the U.S. and a regional ceasefire involving Lebanon, the Bab el-Mandeb was still fully open. Today, maritime traffic through both the chokepoints is disrupted, any regional ceasefire will have to include Yemen, and any final settlement will have to address the Houthis' demands, while Iran's nuclear programme has been pushed to the back burner.

THE GIST

- More than 20% of the world's seaborne oil trade passed through the Strait of Hormuz before the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran
- The Red Sea, which connects Asia and Europe through the Suez Canal in the north and Bab el-Mandeb in the south, typically carries roughly 12-15% of global maritime trade
- Iran and Ansar Allah, one of its closest allies, now have the ability to exert pressure on two of the world's critical maritime chokepoints

'Sacred' demands

BAPS

The Eiffel Tower management's move to replace all women staff with their male colleagues for the visit of a delegation from the religious sect has sparked a backlash in France

G. Sampath

Visitors to Paris's iconic Eiffel Tower last Monday had to turn back in disappointment. The monument was closed following a protest against the management's move to replace all women staff with their male colleagues for the visit of a 100-strong delegation from the Hindu religious sect, Bochasanwasi Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha (BAPS).

The local trade union condemned "workplace instructions that led to female employees being sidelined, replaced and rendered invisible on the basis of gender". A union spokeswoman told the media that it was "a humiliating experience for the women, to be made invisible in a public space."

BAPS is known for adopting strict gender segregation. But the attempted imposition of its belief system in a country that takes pride in its progressive culture and gender norms sparked a swift backlash. Terming the incident "totally shocking and unacceptable", Ariel Weil, the president of the company that runs the Eiffel Tower, announced an internal investigation to fix accountability and ensure it "never happens again".

The incident also had sections of the Indian dias-



AFP

pora worried about an anti-immigrant backlash, with one prominent group, the India Alliance Paris (IAP), posting on social media, "The Eiffel Tower story must not become fodder for more racism. BAPS is a regressive sect, politically connected to India's far-right. It should be treated like the sexist, casteist, backward sect it is. BAPS does not represent all Hindus and it certainly does not represent India."

BAPS, in a statement on X, clarified that the visit was "arranged in conjunction with the Eiffel Tower team" and apologised "for any pain or inconvenience caused".

'Cultural relations'

The visit from the BAPS delegation coincided with the inauguration of a massive Swaminarayan temple in Bussy-Saint-Georges, a Paris suburb. The event was attended by India's Ambassador to France, and the temple was virtually inaugurated by Prime Minister

Narendra Modi. In his video address, Mr. Modi termed the inauguration "a new milestone in the cultural relations between India and France".

BAPS, which gets its name from Bochasan village in Gujarat, was formed as a distinct denomination within the Swaminarayan Sampradaya, or tradition, in 1905. Its followers are predominantly from Gujarat. Mr. Modi had attended the funeral of Pramukh Swami Maharaj, the spiritual head of BAPS, in August 2016. Apart from Mr. Modi, Home Minister Amit Shah and Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani are other prominent Gujaratis who have been seen attending and speaking at BAPS functions.

The abundantly funded religious group, according to its website, has over 1,300 temples across the world and a presence in more than 50 countries. BAPS, however, is no stranger to controversy. It hit global headlines in 2021

following a lawsuit filed in a federal court in New Jersey that accused it of exploiting Indian workers brought to the U.S. on religious-worker (R-1) visas. An R-1 visa is meant for volunteers or devotees engaged in religious work. But the lawsuit claimed that BAPS made them do manual labour, including cutting, grinding, polishing, carving and installing stone, and other heavy construction work.

The litigants claimed that BAPS "intentionally recruited workers from the Scheduled Caste" and subjected them to "forced labor..." A criminal investigation, which began in May 2021 under the Biden administration, was abruptly closed in mid-2025 by Department of Justice officials under the second Trump administration. The civil cases against BAPS, however, remain open.

While every religious sect may be entitled to its customary practices, including some that may not sit well with modern progressive norms, critics have questioned the propriety of the Prime Minister of a constitutionally secular republic not only publicly platforming a particular religious sect but also projecting it as an integral element of India's diplomatic outreach and "special partnership" with another country.

Echoes from the past

Alice Weidel

The AfD leader, who has slammed Germany's culture of remembrance over its Nazi crimes as a 'cult of guilt', is on the ascent after her party's recent regional election victory

Joan Sony Cherian

"Mr. Merz, your time has run out," declared Alice Weidel, the co-leader of Germany's far-right party, the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD), in a speech in the Bundestag after the party's resounding victory in the regional elections in the state of Saxony-Anhalt. Winning the mandate by securing 43% of the vote in Saxony-Anhalt, the AfD has effectively consolidated its position as a front-runner in the next federal elections to be held in 2029.

The AfD, which espouses hard borders, mass detention facilities, deportation of 'illegal' immigrants, remigration, traditional families, Euro-scepticism, German nationalism, and a broader free-market economic policy has found itself a leader who herself is a walking contradiction when it comes to the values that her party espouses. Ms. Weidel, before entering politics (she joined the AfD a few months after its formation in 2013), was an economist and banker. Born in 1979 in Gütersloh, West Germany, Ms. Weidel majored in economics and business before joining Goldman Sachs as an analyst. She also worked for the Bank of China, a state-owned Chinese multinational bank, in the late



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

2000s, living in China for almost six years; she is fluent in Mandarin.

Ms. Weidel is also the first lesbian to lead the AfD. She is in a registered civil partnership with Sarah Bossard, a German national of Sri Lankan origin, and the couple have adopted two children. Yet, Ms. Weidel and the AfD oppose same-sex marriage in Germany, instead emphasising Christian values and the 'traditional family'.

Moreover, even though the AfD has said only 'illegal' immigrants and criminals should be deported, many leaders of the AfD, including Ms. Weidel, have made statements which denounce immigration, especially from Muslim-majority countries, as a whole. In a 2018 speech in the German Parliament, she remarked that "Burqas, girls in headscarves, knife-wielding men on government benefits and other good-for-nothing people are not going to ensure our prosperity, our economic

growth and our social welfare system." Even in her latest victory speech, where she warned Chancellor Friedrich Merz of his coalition government's end, Ms. Weidel claimed that Germany had the largest number of refugees in the world, and that most of them were from "Muslim tribal cultures".

Sense of continuity

Yet Ms. Weidel's ideology, with all its contradictions, does have a sense of continuity when one looks at her heritage. Her grandfather, Hans Weidel, was a supporter and member of the Nazi party and a judge of the regime. He actively campaigned for the National Socialists even before it assumed power. He became a military judge at the Warsaw commandant's office in July 1941, after which he was appointed as the Chief Staff Judge by a direct order from Adolf Hitler himself.

After the fall of Nazi Germany, however, he washed

himself off the regime's crimes, claiming that he did not know anything about the concentration camps. Ms. Weidel has also distanced herself from her grandfather's legacy.

However, Ms. Weidel has often been dismissive about Germany's chequered past. She once said there was a 'cult of guilt/shame' associated with remembering the past. She has remarked that the country's Nazi past is often "politically instrumentalised" against her party.

In 2023, Ms. Weidel, in spite of denouncing Germany's support of Ukraine in the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war refused to attend an event organised by the Russian embassy to commemorate the defeat of the Nazi regime by stating that she did not want to "celebrate the defeat of one's own country".

Despite such contradictions, Ms. Weidel enjoys popularity within the AfD and among its supporters. She has been a member of the Bundestag since 2017, and co-leader of the AfD with Tino Chrupalla since 2022. She was elected by the party to be its first Chancellor nominee for the 2025 federal elections. And judging by the AfD's growing record of electoral victory, it can be assumed that she is gaining favour with the wider German electorate.



Researchers examined the teeth of two ancient hunter-gatherers from Sulawesi, Indonesia, dating back as far as 25,000 years, and found unusual, deep grooves in the teeth caused by sucking on betel nuts. Chemical analyses confirmed the presence of arecoline, the main stimulant in betel nuts, suggesting these early foragers habitually kept whole nuts in their mouths for long periods. The find pushes back the timeline of human drug use by thousands of years.



Anthropic has used its Claude AI to formalise Fermat's Last Theorem using the Lean language. Formalisation means translating human arguments into code so software can verify every logical step from first principles without relying on human trust. While mathematicians had anticipated translating the proof would take five years of painstaking work, Claude achieved it in 11 days, generating over 13 million lines of code and verifying 29,500 intermediate theorems, in a breakthrough for automated reasoning.



As water drops slide over leaves, glass or plastic, they develop an electric charge. When such charged drops land on a metal surface, even one with a protective coating like Teflon, the charge creates an electric field strong enough to punch microscopic holes through the coating, allowing the water to reach the metal below, leading to rust and decay. This new discovery shows a new way in which bridges, ships, cars, and heritage sites may degrade.



Wakey, wakey

The human body has a built-in timekeeping system called the circadian rhythm. It is governed by a group of cells in the brain, centred on the suprachiasmatic nucleus, which uses signals such as daylight to keep the body's roughly 24-hour cycle aligned with the outside world. When you wake up at the same time every day, your brain learns. In the hours before your usual waking time, the body slowly prepares for wakefulness: e.g. levels of the stress hormone begin to rise and body

temperature increases. Over time, these changes can help you wake naturally when you expect to. But this process is not precise. If you wake at 6:57 am when your alarm is set for 7 am, it could be your circadian system doing its job. But if you wake at 6:59 once, it could just be coincidence. We tend to remember the uncanny 'successes', like waking seconds before the alarm, and forget the mornings when we woke at 5:43 for no apparent reason. The phenomenon is thus neither pure coincidence nor pure foresight.

Readers may send their questions / answers to science@thehindu.co.in



The lesson from New York is that any credible response has to be age-tailored, aimed at embedded AI as much as visible chatbots, backed by a real evaluation mechanism, and built with as much attention to what happens on how the child spends their time past school time. India currently has the worst numbers and the weakest safety net. It should not wait for a crisis in every area before it acts.



Zomato starts levying additional fee on COD orders

M. Kalyanaraman

Recycle bin: For Alang, the competent authority to handle the ships is the Gujarat Maritime Board. VIJAY SONEJI

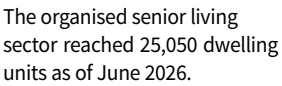
U.S. sanctions

Sanctions by the U.S. will lock the ship owner and related firms out of the mainstream global financial system.

Indian banks and financial firms will therefore not accept transactions involving these entities.

Industry sources say that there is typically an Indian firm in the chain so the immediate transactions of recycling are conducted in rupees but eventually the money could be routed through other channels such as the Hong Kong dollar, digital-crypto currencies, and rupee-rouble exchanges to the firms sanctioned by the U.S.

But the U.S. and other sanctioning entities are not entirely averse to scrap-



Tanking up



Running cost: A truck driver pumps diesel fuel into his tractor-trailer at a truck stop on September 11, 2026 in Miami, Florida. Diesel fuel prices in the U.S. topped \$6 a gallon for the first time ever. AFP

With continued policy support, innovation and access to international markets, India is well positioned to capture a larger share of value across the global jewellery supply chain, Mr. Bhansali added.

Meanwhile, cut and polished diamond exports declined 4.93% year-on-year to \$924.51 million (₹8,828.65 crore), however, in volume terms, they rose by 3.23% to 13.36 lakh carats in August 2026 from 12.94 lakh carats in August 2025, GJEPC data stated.

Silver jewellery exports declined 39.66% to \$86.68 million (₹ 827.20 crore) in August.

N. Korea fires missiles toward sea after rivals' trilateral military drill



U.S. House of Representatives to take up Russia sanctions Bill



Lebanon's President pledges Israeli forces' withdrawal on visit to south



U.S. judge blocks Trump govt.'s 'loyalty' question for job applicants



Anthropic CEO urges AI companies to slow rate of model development

Reuters
NEW YORK

7 killed, dozens injured in Russian strikes on Ukraine

A unified Ireland would be 'fantastic', says U.S. President

Sabotage suspected in French train derailment

India-China flight services to resume after a gap of 6 years

Bin Laden considered targeting India and other countries in 1998: CIA papers

In latest war of words, Eritrea says Ethiopia is destabilising region

The Ethiopian premier's spokesperson did not comment on the allegations.

BIG OCCASION

‘Winning in T20s is all about who plays better cricket on the day’



X@BCCIWOMEN

India skipper Harmanpreet Kaur expects a tough fight in Sunday's Asia Cup final against reigning champion Sri Lanka. “The last time we played Sri Lanka, they came up with some really solid plans and performances. Winning in T20 cricket is all about who plays better cricket on the day,” Harmanpreet said on the eve of the contest.

FLYING START

Flintoff stars as Australia-A romps to win against India-A



FILE PHOTO

Tess Flintoff's four-wicket burst flattened India-A women as they suffered a six-wicket loss against Australia-A in the first match of the T20 series in New Chandigarh. **The scores:** India-A 117 in 19 overs (Flintoff 4/13, Ginger 2/17, Illingworth 2/18) lost to Australia-A 121/4 in 14 overs (Knott 35, Learoyd 33 n.o). **Toss:** India-A.

EVOLVING RAPPORT

Skipper Shreyas at ease with coach Gambhir's working style



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Skipper Shreyas Iyer shed light on his evolving rapport with coach Gautam Gambhir. “Gambhir builds a lot of confidence among the players. The more matches we win, the more we would be getting to know each other. I've worked with him at KKR, so I definitely know how his mind works and how his approach is going to be”.

AMAZING TALENT

‘Onus on simple plans, proper execution against Sooryavanshi’



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi is an amazing talent. We have the knowledge [of how to bowl to him]. A few of our players have played against him in the IPL. We have watched his videos. We want to keep the plans simple and execute them properly — Afghanistan skipper Ibrahim Zadran.

Lanka stands between India and eighth title

Shafali and Deepti key to Harmanpreet & Co.'s chances in a clash between two unbeaten sides; the holder's hopes rest on Chamari

ASIA CUP

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

Seven-time champion India will look to Shafali Verma and Deepti Sharma to deliver once again when it takes on a resilient Sri Lanka in the T20 Asia Cup final at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium on Sunday.

With 168 runs, including two fifties, Shafali has not only been India's best batter but also the leading run-scorer in this edition.

Deepti, the tournament's leading wicket-taker alongside Sri Lanka skipper Chamari Athapaththu (11 scalps), has been at the forefront of India's bowling attack.

While both teams have wind in their sails having gone undefeated in their march to the final, India will be wary of the gritty Sri Lanka side which had handed it a crushing eight-wicket defeat in the last edition's final in 2024.

The teams (from): India: Harmanpreet Kaur (Capt.), Smriti Mandhana (Vice-Capt.), Bharti Fulmali, Richa Ghosh (wk), G. Kamalini (wk), Pratika Rawal, Shafali Verma, Deepti Sharma, Kranti Gaud, Prema Rawat, Arundhati Reddy, Renuka Thakur, Nandani Sharma, Shree Charani, and Radha Yadav.

Sri Lanka: Chamari Athapaththu (Capt.), Harshitha Samarawickrama (Vice-Capt.), Imesha Dulani, Vishmi Gunaratne, Kaushini

Battle for the continental crown
India will look to dethrone Sri Lanka and scale the summit for the eighth time in the Asia Cup



India and Sri Lanka are set to meet in the T20 Asia Cup final for the third consecutive time. While India came up trumps in 2022, Sri Lanka exacted revenge on its rival two years later

Both teams head into the summit clash on the back of a four-match winning streak

India will make its sixth successive appearance in the T20 Asia Cup title decider. It has won three (2012, 2016, 2022) and lost two (2018, 2024)

India is the only side to have defended its crown in the continental competition (includes both formats). Sri Lanka can join the club on Sunday

Both teams have impressive T20 records at the Dubai International Stadium. India has six victories in seven matches and Sri Lanka has four wins in five games

The Indians are atop the batting and bowling charts in the ongoing edition. While opener Shafali Verma is the leading scorer with 168 runs, spinner Deepti Sharma is the joint highest wicket-taker — along with Sri Lanka's Chamari Athapaththu — with 11 scalps

Compiled by S. SHRIVATHSAN

Nuthyanganana (wk), Sanjana Kavindi, Hasini Perera, Nilakshika Silva, Kavisha Dilhari, Mithali Ayodhya, Kavya Kavindi,

Sugandika Kumari, Nimasha Meepage, Chamudi Praboda, and Chethana Vimukhti.

Match starts at 8 p.m. IST.

Pipers advance to the final as Masters lend a helping hand

GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

The only way Magnus Carlsen's Alpine APL Pipers could make it to the Global Chess League final after the 6-11 loss to Triveni Continental Kings in the day's first match was a victory for CheQ Mumba Masters in the last league clash against Fyers American Gambits. And it obliged.

Masters won an edge-of-the-seat thriller 11-6, but it easily could have gone the other way around, and Gambits, playing at home, would have been in Sunday's final.

Nihal Sarin was in a winning position against M. Pranesh, but the Kerala GM blundered under severe time pressure, and then went on to lose on time.

Gambits' biggest star, Javokhir Sindarov, did his bit, beating Maxime Vachier-Lagrave on the Icon board, but that wasn't going to be enough.



Tough going: Carlsen went down to Firouzja. SUDHAKARA JAIN

Pipers will take on Ganges Grandmasters in the match for the top prize in season four at the Lalit Ashok.

Grandmasters also tasted defeat in their last league last match, going down 7-9 to PBG Alaskan Knights. But their superior game points tally ensured a ticket for the final.

At the end of the double round-robin league, Grandmasters and Pipers finished with 18 match-points.

Grandmasters topped the table by virtue of higher game points, 95 against Pipers' 88.

Gambits and Masters scored 15 match points

each and will contest the playoff for the third place.

The results:
Alpine Pipers lost to Continental Kings 6-11 (Carlsen lost to Firouzja; Giri drew with Wei; Vidit lost to Aravindh; Divya drew with Zhu; Humpy drew with Kosteniuk; Murzin bt Pranav).

Alaskan Knights bt Ganges Grandmasters 9-7 (Anand drew with Nepomniachtchi; Arjun drew with Aronian; Erdogmus drew with Perez; Lagno drew with Shuvalova; Batsiasvili lost to Stavroula Tsolakidou; Abhimanyu bt Mendonca).

Mumba Masters bt American Gambits 11-6 (Vachier-Lagrave lost to Sindarov; Pranesh bt Nihal; Mamedyarov drew with Dubov; Harika drew with Assaubayeva; Yip bt Sarasadat; Daneshvar bt Maurizil).

Ahead of Asian Games, India aims to flex muscle

CRICKET

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

In a year when India and Afghanistan have locked horns in a one-off Test and three ODIs, there is a feeling of familiarity as the Asian sides meet again for a T20I series.

This will be uncharted territory, however, given the quirk of Afghanistan being the official host for a three-game assignment in the heart of India's capital city.

The Afghans have played 'home' ties in India previously, but never against the Men in Blue. The timing of the series — India's international home season usually begins in the month of October — is another peculiarity.

Once the action gets underway beneath the twilight sky at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Sunday, India

will hope for no more deviations from convention as Shreyas Iyer & Co. look to enter the Asian Games in Japan in red-hot form. India, which won the T20 World Cup in March for a second successive title, starts the series as the clear favourite. But it will not want to run the risk of resting on its laurels, especially after a shock series defeat to Ireland in June in Shreyas' first assignment as full-time skipper.

The 31-year-old's start to life in the hot seat has been bumpy. Having also suffered a 0-4 rout at the hands of England following the Ireland setback, it took a three-match tour of Zimbabwe for Shreyas to revel in the aftermath of a maiden victory as captain.

In southern Africa, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi played his part with two half-centuries, providing a glowing reflection of the prodigious skill bursting through his veins. The 15-year-old



The prize: Afghanistan skipper Zadran and India captain Shreyas with the Friendship Cup. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

southpaw may have had a challenging initiation against Jofra Archer & Co., but looked right at ease whilst faying the Zimbabwe attack in Harare. The Afghans, who possess the pace of Naveen-ul-Haq and Fazalhaq Farooqi, will certainly try to examine the teen with the short-pitched play. It is a test that

the star would want to embrace with glee.

With a fit-again Jasprit Bumrah back to operating at full tilt, meanwhile, the frailties that were laid bare with the ball in the United Kingdom shouldn't resurface. He may be turning 33 in December, but remains the undisputed spearhead of the Indian pace pack.

If India is getting accustomed to Shreyas' leadership style, Afghanistan is in the process of absorbing the ideas of the new captain-coach combination of Ibrahim Zadran and Richard Pybus.

The next three T20Is may offer some indications of their imprint on the team.

The teams (from): Afghanistan: Ibrahim Zadran (Capt.), Darwish Rasooli, Noor ul Rahman (wk), Rahmanullah Gurbaz (wk), Sediqullah Atal, Azmatullah Omarzai, Gulbadin Naib, Mohammad Nabi, Nangeyalia Kharote, Rashid Khan, Abdullah Ahmadzai, Fazalhaq Farooqi, Mujeeb Ur Rahman, Naveen-ul-Haq, and Noor Ahmad.

India: Shreyas Iyer (Capt.), Tilak Varma, Abhishek Sharma, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Sanju Samson (wk), Ishan Kishan (wk), Shivam Dube, Nitish Kumar, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Varun Chakaravarthy, Ravi Bishnoi, Jasprit Bumrah, Arshdeep Singh, and Yash Thakur.

Match starts at 7 p.m.

Liverpool and Chelsea drop points to Fulham and Hull

EURO LEAGUES

Agencies
LONDON

Liverpool and Chelsea dropped more points in the Premier League after being held to draws at home on Saturday.

Liverpool couldn't find a way past winless Fulham in a goal-less draw at Anfield.

Chelsea's fragile defence was exposed again by newly promoted Hull in a 2-2 draw. Aston Villa's nightmare start continued with a 1-2 loss at home to Nottingham Forest.

The results: Premier League:



Hull City's Belloumi celebrates. REUTERS

Aston Villa 1 (Alysson 74) lost to Nottingham Forest 2 (Delap 46, Jesus 88); Bournemouth 2 (Kluivert 38, Tavernier 52) drew with Brentford 2 (Schade 34, 56). Chelsea 2 (Rogers 7, Joao Pedro

66) drew with Hull 2 (Belloumi 28, 34); Crystal Palace 2 (Khalaili 34, Strand Larsen 75) lost to Ipswich 3 (Emersonn 23, Davis 45, Flemming 90); Liverpool 0 drew with Fulham 0.

Bundesliga: Borussia Dortmund 3 (Silva 5, Nmecha 80, 89) bt Paderborn 0; Hoffenheim 2 (Hlozek 13, 67) bt Stuttgart 1 (Mittelstaedt 48); Freiburg 5 (Engelhardt 23, 79, Matanovic 29, 77, Eggestein 86) bt Borussia M'Gladbach 0; Augsburg 2 (Gregoritsch 50, 55) drew with Bayer Leverkusen 2 (Kofane 18, Schick 89); Mainz 1 (Tietz 89) lost to Eintracht Frankfurt 3 (Uzun 9, 60, Burkardt 45+1).

On Friday: LaLiga: Sevilla 1 (Iglesias 81) bt Valencia 0.

Bundesliga: Union Berlin 1 (Skarke 90+6) lost to Schalke 04 3 (Gosens 25, Aouchiche 46, Woerber 90+13).

Duplantis and Ingebrigtsen steal the show on first day

ULTIMATE CSHIP

Agence France-Presse
BUDAPEST

Scandinavian stars Armand Duplantis and Jakob Ingebrigtsen shone on the opening day of the inaugural Ultimate Championship here on Friday.

With unmatched prize money totalling \$10 million on offer over 28 disciplines, Duplantis and Ingebrigtsen walked away with \$150,000 each for winning the men's pole vault and 5,000m, respectively.

Swede Duplantis cleared 6.20 metres for victory ahead of Greek rival Emmanouil Karalis while Norway's Ingebrigtsen continued his comeback from injury with a stunning win, clocking 12:59.24.

Two of this season's



Business as usual: Duplantis came up with an effort of 6.20m to underline his supremacy in pole vault. AFP

World record holders, Masai Russell and Ja'Kobe Tharp, duly won their short hurdles races. Russell reeled in the 100m hurdles field after a sluggish start for victory in 12.22 ahead of Nigeria's Tobi Amusan (12.34). Russell's US teammate Tharp edged World champion Cordell Tinch by one-hundredth of a second for 110m hurdles victory in 12.94. The first title went to the United States in the

4x100m mixed relay, giving them a shared pot of \$80,000. The quartet of Ronnie Baker, Anavia Battle, Courtney Lindsey and Kayla White clocked 39.64s ahead of World record holders Jamaica (39.72) and Britain (40.26) rounding out the podium.

Germany's Merlin Hummel was the surprise winner of the men's hammer throw with an attempt of 81.46m.



Seven years after a flood in 2019, members of the Vaniyampuzha tribal hamlet are still living under plastic sheets. SAKEEER HUSSAIN

Over two dozen Paniya tribal families are living in plastic sheds set up in forested areas across the Chaliyar river in Malappuram district. Abdul Latheef Naha takes a trip to the tribal settlement to bring out the plight of the tribespeople

Makeshift existence

The river was rising fast. There was no time to even gather their belongings. Men, women and children ran uphill into the dark forest as the Chaliyar river swallowed part of the Vaniyampuzha tribal hamlet in Malappuram district. It was August 8, 2019.

By the time the water receded, their homes were gone. The bridges were washed away, cutting them off from the mainland. They thought they would return home. Seven years later, they are still living under plastic sheets. At night, the forest turns pitch dark. There is no electricity. Elephants move through the settlement. Leopards stalk goats and dogs. Women here are forced to wait until dark to venture into the bushes to relieve themselves.

For the 26 tribal families of the Vaniyampuzha tribal hamlet, the temporary shelter has become a permanent address.

A couple of years later, half the families moved downhill, splitting Vaniyampuzha into upper and lower hamlets. Together, they now number 161: 70 members above and 91 below. Their old settlement lies where the Vaniyampuzha river, descending from the Wayanad hills, meets the Chaliyar river. The flood destroyed several houses; those that survived remain empty. No family has returned. The hamlet has been declared unfit for habitation. So they stayed on the hill.

“There is still a risk,” says Babu P., a forest watcher. “Parts of the hills could come down. We have seen how devastating floods can be.” There is also a belief among the tribespeople that returning to a deserted home brings bad luck. The abandoned anganwadi and badal school still stand, now play spaces for children.

The flood also destroyed two concrete bridges linking Vaniyampuzha and the neighbouring hamlets of Tharippappotti, Thandankallu, Iruttukuthy and Kumbalappara to Munderi on the mainland. For years, bamboo rafts were the only way across in the monsoon, the swollen river became a gamble. Pregnant women, patients and children had to be carried across. At times, even Fire and Rescue Services personnel could not cross the river.

“We depended solely on bamboo rafts to cross the river,” says Sudha V.K., an Accredited Social Health Activist (ASHA). “Now we are used to it. But when the river gets swollen, we know the risk.”

A new bridge is ready after seven years, still awaiting inauguration. “We don’t have any security. After seven years, the only thing we received was a bridge,” says Gireesh S., a rubber tapper.

But it will not solve the problems upstream. Tharippappotti and Kumbalappara each have more than 20 families. Tharippappotti and Vaniyampuzha are home mainly to Paniya tribespeople; Kumbalappara has Kattunaikar families.

A frail hanging bridge links Vaniyampuzha and Tharippappotti. “I don’t know whether it will withstand another severe monsoon,” says Vishnu V.K., a labourer. For residents of Tharippappotti and Kumbalappara, serious illness still means being carried through the forest.

Housing troubles

Housing remains a bigger struggle. After leaving the old hamlet, the families from Vaniyampuzha sought new land; but technical hurdles emerged since they already had land recorded in their names. “Because receiving land got delayed, house too has been delayed,” Babu says.

Integrated Tribal Development Project (ITDP) officer Vipin Das Y. says the Record of Rights, an official document on ownership, tenancy, and fi-



Let a government official or a responsible person stay with us at night. They will feel the difference. They will experience what we feel and undergo

SUDHA V.K.
ASHA

nancial liabilities of land, has been cleared for 39 families in Vaniyampuzha and Tharippappotti, and special sanction has been sought to build houses. “We have submitted a ₹2.46-crore housing proposal, and it is expected to be cleared soon,” he says.

Anil Kumar Babu, a member of Pothukal panchayat, says he is pushing for the work to begin. “I am doing my best to help people. We expect to begin work on the houses in a few months,” he says. The Public Works department (PWD) has prepared a road project for Tharippappotti, while a bridge across the Vaniyampuzha river is under proposal. Meanwhile, the families are growing. “We are looking forward to safe houses for our children, who want to set up homes of their own after marriage,” says Sudha. “We hope we will have them soon.”

Soon after the flood, voluntary organisations supplied tarpaulin sheets and other relief materials. The families say they received more help from them than the government. “We have changed the tarpaulin sheets several times,” says Sathesh V.K., rubber plantation worker.

Plastic shelters

But plastic offers little protection. In summer, the shelters become unbearably hot. “It is very hot even at night,” Sudha says. “Sometimes we sleep outside with our children in spite of the dangers.”

Before the flood, the families had houses with electricity. They lost both homes and power in 2019. Soon after the disaster, the Subcollector promised electricity through underground cables. Nothing came of it.

“What we get is often promises and promises, and nothing else,” Sathesh says.

Then came a bitter reminder of the old life: a Kerala State Electricity Board (KSEB) power bill, months after the flood had destroyed their homes. “We were startled by the bill. We had to get the ward member intervene to address that issue,” says Vishnu.

Today, mobile phones are lamps. Those without torches use their phones until the batteries die. To charge them, the residents have to walk half a kilometre to the Vaniyampuzha forest station. The families live in an elephant corridor. Elephants sometimes break through electric fences and enter areas where residents try to grow crops. “We cannot cultivate anything,” Babu says. “The electric fencing is not perfect. Ele-



Children from Vaniyampuzha and neighbouring hamlets attend schools at Munderi, Nettiikkulam and Pothukal. SAKEEER HUSSAIN

phants break it.” In June 2025, a 56-year-old tribal man, Billy, was killed in an elephant attack. The swollen river prevented immediate medical help. Even Fire and Rescue Services personnel could not cross the river using their dinghy because of the strong current.

Leopards are another threat. “My dog was like a child to me,” Sudha says. “A leopard took it away from next to me while I was sleeping.”

The families say leopards have not attacked people. But they remain wary after dark.

Women wait for night

The lack of toilets is another daily indignity. “Our men can somehow manage in the bushes,” Sudha says. “But women have to wait until night. It is extremely difficult.”

The issue reached the Kerala High Court after the intervention of Aryadan Shoukath, now MLA of Nilambur. Following the court’s intervention, ITDP installed a bio-toilet each at Vaniyampuzha and Tharippappotti in 2024. They have since become unusable. “They are already full,” says Pushpa, 43. “So we have no choice but to go in the open.”

Senior Civil Judge M. Shabir Ibrahim had visited the hamlet after the court intervention. “It was terrible. We tried everything possible to help

them out,” he says. Water is another problem. Wells are being constructed, but work remains incomplete. At times, families have to move to places where water is available.

The crisis has followed the children into school. Children from the hamlets attend schools at Munderi, Nettiikkulam and Pothukal. Transport remains difficult; efforts are being made to take them by tractor to the new bridge.

But getting children to school is only part of the problem. “The dropout rate is very high,” Vishnu says.

Babu says many parents need greater awareness about education. The families cite alcohol as a major reason for dropouts.

“Many parents drink and fight in front of their children,” Sudha says. “Some children have stopped going to school because of the quarrels at home. Repeated awareness sessions are a must.”

Some children stay in hostels at Model Residential Schools in Nilambur and Wayanad. Others return home and struggle to go back. Some attend only two or three periods before returning.

The deadly 2024 landslides at Mundakkai and Chooralmala in Wayanad revived the terror of 2019. Human remains from the disaster were washed ashore. “That was a terrible time,” says Gireesh.

The residents know what it means to wait for help. In August 2019, while the world focussed on the Kavalappara tragedy, where 59 people were buried alive, Vaniyampuzha had remained cut off.

“We had seen helplessness and hunger then,” Sudha says. “We had no food. No communication.”

Seven years later, the bridge is ready. They are still waiting for houses. There is still no electricity, usable toilet or reliable water. Children continue to drop out of schools. Families still sleep beneath plastic sheets in a forest that was never meant to be their home. Sudha wants those who make decisions about their lives to spend one night there.

“Let a government official or a responsible person stay with us at night,” she says. “They will feel the difference. They will experience what we feel and undergo.”

The people of Vaniyampuzha are not asking to reclaim the houses the river destroyed. They want safe homes, electricity, water and toilets. They want their children to stay in school. They want to cross the river without fear.



Water is another problem in the tribal hamlets. At times, families have to move to places where water is available. SAKEEER HUSSAIN

KARNATAKA



Declining numbers: According to data from the Ministry of External Affairs, the number of students going abroad from India has now decreased by about 40%. In 2026, only two lakh to three lakh students have gone to foreign universities.

When foreign universities come home

Foreign universities have taken steps to establish their off-shore campuses with the permission of the University Grants Commission. While one section feels that this is a good development, there are others who argue that Indian students will be better off studying at the parent campus of foreign universities, interacting with foreign students, and having multicultural exchanges. **Jayanth R.** takes a look

Until recently, some 7 lakh students from India used to go to foreign universities every year. The United States of America, Australia, Canada, England, and Germany were among the key destinations. According to the Ministry of External Affairs data, the number of students going abroad from India has now decreased by about 40%. This year, only 2 lakh to 3 lakh students have gone to foreign universities.

At the same time, an increasing number of foreign universities are pitching their tents in India, opening their offshore campuses here and offering the “foreign-educated” tag. Bengaluru appears to be one of the key destinations for many of them, with two universities – one each from Australia and the United Kingdom – already opening their campuses and starting academic activities from 2026-27, while more are in the pipeline.

Driven by the National Education Policy (NEP-2020), foreign universities have taken steps to establish their off-shore campuses with the permission of the University Grants Commission (UGC).

While one section feels that the arrival of foreign universities will bring in foreign research, increase new innovations, enhance tourism and foster intellectual growth, there are those who argue that Indian students will be better off studying at the parent campus of foreign universities, interacting with foreign students and having multicultural exchanges. There is also a fear that foreign universities will have an impact on local universities.



How rules have changed

Earlier, foreign universities were not allowed to operate directly in India. However, many higher educational institutions were operating in collaboration with foreign universities for research activities, cultural and student exchange and other programmes.

Students who wanted a foreign university degree would go abroad, some on government and university scholarships. Many students used to find placements through educational consultancies or agencies at their own expenses.

But in recent years, countries such as the U.S. and Canada have tightened student visa rules, while Australia has increased student visa fees by a huge margin. The number of students going abroad has also fallen significantly owing to higher tuition fees, with the value of the rupee constantly falling against the U.S. dollar and education loans getting more expensive, among other reasons.

At this juncture, NEP-2020, implemented by the Union government from 2022, allowed foreign universities to operate in the country. Since then, around 18 global ranking universities have been approved by the University Grants Commission (UGC) to open campuses in India. Seven of them are from Australia.

Two foreign universities have already started

These universities produce graduates with global-level qualifications. Where they secure employment depends on the individual. Our primary focus is delivering global-quality education for a range of jurisdictions

PHILIP GREEN,
Australia’s High Commissioner to India

operations in Bengaluru. Australia’s University of New South Wales (UNSW) and the U.K.-based University of Liverpool have established campuses at Manyata Business Park and the Alembic City complex in Bengaluru.

Four other foreign institutions – Imperial College London, Lancaster University, La Trobe University and Flinders University – are planning to start operations in and around Bengaluru.

To apply at these universities, English language proficiency is a must. At UNSW, students have to prove their proficiency, if English is not their first language, and the University of Liverpool demands a minimum 70% in English language at class 12 in any board.

University of Liverpool offers BSc (Hons) and Masters in Accounting and Finance, Biomedical sciences, Computer Science, Computer Science and Software Development, Game Design, and BA in Business Management.

UNSW has started Bachelor’s programmes in Business, Computer Science, Data Science and Decisions, Media, Public Relations and Advertising and Masters in Cyber Security.

What it costs

Though not comparable to what it costs to study abroad, degrees here too come with a heavy price tag. Undergraduate (UG) courses at UNSW charge around ₹15 lakh for Indian residents per year and for Masters in Cyber Security, it is around ₹19 lakh for resident Indians and ₹22 lakh for Non Resident Indians.

The annual fee structure at University of Liverpool ranges between ₹11.5 lakh for undergraduate programmes and ₹15 lakh for the postgraduate ones. However, the universities offer scholarships for eligible students.

Bengaluru, favourite destination

Many foreign universities are eager to set up their campuses in Bengaluru for many reasons, including the State government’s policies that make processes simpler, technology availability, and access to qualified human resources.

Suresh Renukappa, Director of JSS AHER-Wolverhampton Centre for Future Healthcare and Policy Innovation University of Wolverhampton, U.K., said: “The NEP-2020 created an enabling environment for internationalisation, and subsequent regulatory developments have provided clearer routes for foreign universities to establish a presence in India. International universities also see India’s demographic scale, demand for higher education, expanding middle class, rapidly growing innovation economy and increasing global importance.”

“Bengaluru is particularly attractive because it combines higher education, technology, entrepreneurship, multinational companies, start-ups, healthcare, research and a

highly skilled workforce within one ecosystem. For a university, that is extremely important,” he said.

“Students can potentially receive an international education and qualification without bearing the full financial and personal cost of studying overseas. This emerging model is already visible in programmes offered in India in areas such as computer science, AI, data science, finance and business. But the benefits should go beyond the degree. A successful international campus should provide students with international curricula, global faculty engagement, industry exposure, research opportunities, and access to international networks,” he said.

Australia too is aggressively expanding its higher education footprint in India, shifting from traditional institutional alliances toward major new partnerships and dedicated physical branch campuses.

Australia’s High Commissioner to India, Philip Green, said Bengaluru has emerged as one of the primary areas for this expansion, highlighted by the UNSW securing formal regulatory clearance to open a campus in the city. “Australia is the first country to establish foreign branch campuses in India. Two Australian universities are already operational in Gujarat’s GIFT City. Following them, five more are scheduled to open across the country. Each of these universities has a unique plan regarding student intake, course offerings, and employment pipelines,” he noted.

When queried if Indian graduates from these local Australian campuses would secure employment directly in Australia, Philip emphasised what he called “borderless value attached to higher-education and skill sets.”

“These universities produce graduates with global-level qualifications. Where they secure employment depends on the individual. Our primary focus is delivering global-quality education for a range of jurisdictions,” he said.

To maximise outcomes, the Australian High Commission is linking inbound universities with Australian companies in India. “We are mapping out internships that Australian corporates in India can offer to these students, ultimately building direct pathways to employment,” he explained.

Little room for regulation

However, there have also been some concerns over how the State government cannot regulate these entities, be it in terms of fees, reservation of seats for native students or Constitution-based reservations policies.

The Higher Education Department has clarified that foreign universities are autonomous institutions and have received permission directly from the UGC. “We have provided the necessary infrastructure to operate in our State. Otherwise, all administrative decisions, including fees, curriculum, examinations are up to the respective universities,” an official said.

While the State government has withdrawn the NEP-2020 in higher education from 2025-26 and implemented the recommendations of the State Education Policy (SEP) Commission, foreign universities lie outside its purview. The State government has decided to provide

space in the KWIN City to foreign universities. To invite foreign universities to Karnataka, M.B. Patil, Minister for Large and Medium Industries, held a roadshow in the U.K. and held a series of strategic meetings, ahead of the Invest Karnataka-2025.

Where do these developments leave private consultants? Shiva Krishna, a study abroad consultant in Bengaluru, said that entities like them continue to play an important role in enrolments. “Many of these universities invite consultancies and agencies for campus visits and explain the courses, facilities etc. But there is still confusion over whether the students should be admitted to Indian campuses or sent to foreign campuses,” he said.

He emphasised that the quality of education and experience is key. “To get admission in universities abroad, students have to face a separate exam. There is no exam for admission to foreign universities campuses in India. It is important to maintain quality. Also, foreign universities starting campuses in India should not just give degrees to students, but should give them real experience of studying abroad. If Indians are 5% of the students abroad, those from other countries form the 95%. The same kind of environment should be created here too. If 100% of the students are Indian here, the concept of a foreign university will not be fulfilled,” he stated.

Career counsellor Ameene-Mudassar too believes that with foreign universities opening campuses in India, Indian students would miss out on the chance to immerse themselves in the multiculturalism abroad.

“When students go abroad, they spend money there, eat their food, meet people from different countries and different cultures. For example, Sundar Pichai, CEO of Google, Satya Nadella, CEO of Microsoft and other Indian origin CEOs went abroad, studied there and groomed themselves on the world stage. Therefore, a grooming environment is very important for students. Students may miss out on all these global opportunities here,” he said.

Students’ take

Students too have mixed opinions. Monica C.G., a student from Bengaluru who intends to pursue her Master’s degree abroad, said, “I want to pursue a postgraduate degree in the U.S. But owing to strict visa rules and high fees, my parents are suggesting that I continue my education in foreign universities that are starting in India. However, the curriculum, technology, research activities of U.S. universities are advanced compared to those in other countries. I am worried that if I study in India, I will miss this. Higher education is not just about getting a certificate. So, I am very confused.”

Taking a different view, another student, Minarva said: “Instead of leaving my friends and family and going abroad, it is better to study in a foreign university that is starting in our country. The cost will be less too.”

Impact on local universities

A section of academics argue that while the arrival of foreign universities in India has many advantages, they could adversely impact public universities.

A.N. Prabhu Dev, former Vice-Chancellor of Bangalore University, said, “Our public universities have a 40% to 50% shortage of permanent staff. Most universities depend on guest lectures for their academic activities. In such a situation, if foreign universities come and pay higher salaries, our best faculty may leave their jobs and go to foreign universities. The number of students in universities will also fall.”

He argued that the government should focus on quality education in public universities by providing necessary infrastructure and filling vacancies.

